

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 5

Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	8 — How the Land Becomes Sacred
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Apex-tier traps: confusing the semantic core of 'tirtha' (a crossing toward a higher state) with surface features (water, height, age, ownership); collapsing the three networks (char dham 4, jyotirlingas 12-Shiva, Shakti pithas 51-Sati) or swapping their counts/deities; treating shared cross-faith sites, the pilgrimage-trade overlap, or sacred-grove conservation as the OPPOSITE of what the chapter argues; reading the Kumbh's 4-city, ~12-year Jupiter-Sun rotation as yearly or single-place; mistaking which religions originated in India; and treating sacred geography as dividing rather than integrating, or as unique to India. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A geographer maps four phenomena and asks which one would still make the chapter's case that 'the land itself becomes sacred' even if every built temple in India vanished overnight. Which survives that test?

- (A) A single grand temple rebuilt taller than before
- (B) The largest stone shrine on the highest peak
- (C) A government register listing the country's holy buildings
- (D) Rivers, hills, forests and pilgrim journeys revered in their own right, independent of any building

2. Three students each give a one-word root-meaning for 'tirtha'. Whose answer best preserves the deeper sense the chapter draws from the word, rather than just its literal surface?

- (A) 'River' — because sacred sites must sit on water
- (B) 'Peak' — because the holiest sites reach upward

(C) 'Nectar' — because tirthas grant immortality

(D) 'Crossing' — a passage from ordinary life toward a higher, spiritual state

3. A debater argues: 'Since tirtha means a river-crossing, a hilltop shrine and an ocean-edge temple cannot truly be tirthas.' What is the precise flaw in this reasoning?

(A) It is correct, because only riverbank sites are ever called tirthas

(B) It treats the literal ford as the whole meaning, ignoring that any place imagined as a crossing to a higher realm counts as a tirtha

(C) It is correct, because hills and oceans belong to different religions

(D) It wrongly assumes hilltop shrines exist at all

4. In Jainism a 'Tirthankara' shares its root with 'tirtha'. A teacher asks what this shared root reveals about how holiness is conceived. The strongest answer is that a Tirthankara is honoured as one who:

(A) Builds the tallest shrine to mark a sacred site

(B) Grants ford-side land tax-free to pilgrims

(C) Forms a new river where two streams meet

(D) Makes a 'crossing' possible — a supreme teacher who helps others pass toward liberation

5. A pilgrim plans a single loop touching all four char dham. Which feature of the route best demonstrates the chapter's point that these four were positioned to bind the subcontinent together?

(A) The loop stays inside one northern mountain valley

(B) All four stops fall within a single city

(C) The loop reaches the far north, west, east and south, so completing it crosses the whole country

(D) The loop never leaves a hundred-kilometre radius

6. A quiz lists: char dham, jyotirlingas, Shakti pithas. Which single statement gets ALL THREE of their traditional counts right while also naming the correct deity focus where the chapter specifies one?

(A) Char dham 4, jyotirlingas 12 dedicated to Shiva, Shakti pithas 51 linked to the goddess

(B) Char dham 12, jyotirlingas 4 dedicated to Vishnu, Shakti pithas 51 linked to the goddess

(C) Char dham 4, jyotirlingas 51 dedicated to Shiva, Shakti pithas 12 linked to the goddess

(D) Char dham 4, jyotirlingas 12 dedicated to the goddess, Shakti pithas 51 dedicated to Shiva

7. By tradition the 51 Shakti pithas mark spots where parts of Sati's body fell across the land. A historian asks what cultural work this 'scattering' story performed. The best answer

is that it:

- (A) Confined goddess worship to a single northern shrine
- (B) Sealed each region's worship off from every other
- (C) Converted the 51 sites into 12 jyotirlingas over time
- (D) Wove far-apart regions into one shared goddess-landscape spanning the subcontinent

8. A student insists that 'only the religion that began in India can have sacred sites here, so Sufi dargahs and churches don't count.' The chapter's sharpest correction is that:

- (A) Only the single oldest religion has genuine sacred sites
- (B) Outside faiths simply renamed older temples and added nothing
- (C) Sacred sites belong only to faiths the government recognises
- (D) Almost every religion in India, whether born here or arrived from outside, marks its own holy places across the land

9. Four groups of religions are offered. Which group contains ONLY faiths that originated in India?

- (A) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Islam
- (B) Hinduism, Sikhism, Christianity and Jainism
- (C) Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism
- (D) Buddhism, Jainism, Zoroastrianism and Hinduism

10. A Sufi dargah near a town draws Hindus, Muslims and others to the same shrine on the same day. The chapter would treat this scene chiefly as evidence against which mistaken belief?

- (A) That pilgrimage in India is a very ancient practice
- (B) That natural places can also be sacred
- (C) That pilgrimage and trade routes overlapped
- (D) That every sacred site in India belongs to one religion alone

11. A pilgrim complains that the steep, exhausting climb to a hilltop shrine is wasted effort. Which reply best matches the meaning the chapter assigns to such hardship?

- (A) The climb exists only to keep weaker pilgrims away from the shrine
- (B) The hardship is an accident of terrain with no significance
- (C) The toil of the outer climb is felt to mirror the inner effort of spiritual growth, so the difficulty itself carries meaning
- (D) The climb proves which pilgrim is physically strongest

12. Suppose all of India's holy sites had been built clustered inside one small district. The chapter's argument about national INTEGRATION would weaken most directly because:

- (A) The sites would lose every connection to rivers and confluences
- (B) Pilgrims would no longer make long journeys that carried people, ideas and customs between far-apart regions

- (C) Festivals at the sites would be cancelled for want of crowds
- (D) The government would refuse to call clustered sites holy

13. A historian overlays a map of old pilgrimage routes on a map of old trade routes and finds they nearly coincide. The chapter's best explanation for the overlap is that:

- (A) Custom assigned pilgrims and traders entirely separate roads
- (B) Trade routes were laid only after pilgrimage had ended
- (C) The same well-travelled roads carried both pilgrims and traders, so the two networks naturally shared paths
- (D) The match is coincidence with no underlying reason

14. Which single discovery would most powerfully UNDERMINE the chapter's claim that pilgrimage and trade were intertwined?

- (A) Evidence that some shrines stood at busy crossroads
- (B) Evidence that festivals drew huge crowds to riverbanks
- (C) Firm evidence that pilgrims and merchants always used deliberately separate, non-shared roads
- (D) Evidence that pilgrims travelled great distances to reach shrines

15. A sangam is honoured as a tirtha. Which reasoning correctly explains WHY a confluence fits the tirtha idea so well?

- (A) The rivers stop flowing there, so the still water becomes holy
- (B) Bathing is forbidden there, which deepens its mystery
- (C) It marks the tax boundary between two kingdoms
- (D) Waters meeting and crossing there embody the very notion of a sacred crossing-point

16. A child says, 'The Kumbh Mela happens every year in the same town.' How many distinct factual errors does this sentence contain, according to the chapter?

- (A) None — the sentence is entirely correct
- (B) One — only the timing is wrong
- (C) Two — it is not yearly, and it does not stay in one fixed town
- (D) Three — the town, the timing and the festival's existence are all wrong

17. What governs WHEN and WHERE each Kumbh Mela is held?

- (A) The first heavy rainfall of each monsoon, at whichever city floods
- (B) The positions of Jupiter and the Sun on a roughly twelve-year cycle, rotating among four cities
- (C) An annual vote among local kings choosing the host city
- (D) The completion of a new temple, which triggers the next fair

18. The name 'Kumbh Mela' joins two words. Tracing the 'kumbh' half to its legend, what does it recall?

- (A) A mountain from which a sacred river was said to spring
- (B) A pot — specifically the pot that held amrita, the nectar of immortality
- (C) A crown placed on the first king to bathe in the river
- (D) A fig tree under which the fair was first proclaimed

19. At the Kumbh, the great bathing happens at the river or its sangam. Linking the festival to a confluence chiefly reinforces which earlier idea of the chapter?

- (A) That a sangam is itself a sacred crossing-place fitting the tirtha idea, which is why it draws vast crowds
- (B) That the festival has no real connection to rivers
- (C) That confluences are shunned because bathing there is banned
- (D) That the Kumbh actually takes place on a remote hilltop

20. A sacred mountain is described as a 'gateway to heaven.' This phrasing best demonstrates which broader claim of the chapter?

- (A) That only flat plains, never heights, can be sacred
- (B) That geography, culture and spirituality fuse so a landform itself carries religious meaning
- (C) That geography and religion are deliberately kept apart in India
- (D) That mountains matter only as borders no one may cross

21. River and confluence worship in India is said to reach back to which period, marking it among the oldest of practices?

- (A) At least Vedic times
- (B) Only the last hundred years, as a modern movement
- (C) Only the centuries after the Gupta empire fell
- (D) Only the age of large modern cities

22. The Bodhi tree under which the Buddha gained enlightenment was a peepal. The chapter uses this fact mainly to argue that:

- (A) Only fig trees, and nothing else in Nature, can ever be holy
- (B) Sacredness in India is limited to temples and buildings
- (C) The Buddha forbade reverence for any natural place
- (D) Living elements of Nature, not only built shrines, can be sacred

23. The English word 'banyan' is traced to the 'banias' (traders) who rested in the tree's shade. The chapter highlights this etymology chiefly to show that:

- (A) The banyan was sacred only to traders and no one else
- (B) Traders were forbidden from resting near sacred trees
- (C) Economic life and sacred or cultural life were closely interwoven in India
- (D) Trees were named only after the kings who planted them

- 24.** Which botanical feature of the banyan does the chapter give to explain how one tree can shade a whole gathering of people?
- (A) Its leaves turn to gold each spring, widening the canopy
 - (B) Its hanging aerial roots grow downward and harden into new trunks, spreading the tree widely
 - (C) Its trunk is naturally made of stone, letting it grow huge
 - (D) Its flowers bloom only during the Kumbh, drawing crowds
- 25.** A grove beside a village shelters rare birds and a year-round spring, yet has no fence, guard or government notice. The chapter would attribute its survival to:
- (A) Community belief that the grove is a deity's home, so harming it would offend the divine
 - (B) Strict state laws enforced by regular police patrols
 - (C) A tall boundary wall with permanently locked gates
 - (D) Yearly cash payments the king makes to the villagers
- 26.** That sacred groves have preserved biodiversity for centuries WITHOUT legal protection is offered by the chapter as evidence for which general lesson?
- (A) Conservation succeeds only when enforced by the police
 - (B) Cultural belief can be a powerful tool for protecting the environment
 - (C) Religious belief always damages the natural environment
 - (D) Forests can be protected only inside city limits
- 27.** Treating a forest grove as a deity's home is said to do 'double duty' in the chapter's argument. The two things it accomplishes at once are:
- (A) It expresses reverence for Nature AND conserves a living ecosystem
 - (B) It turns the forest into state land AND obliges police to guard it
 - (C) It invites villagers to log it AND to mine it for quick income
 - (D) It proves only buildings are sacred AND that forests never are
- 28.** Four offerings are made to define a 'punyakshetra', a place where geography, culture and spirituality fuse. Which one fits?
- (A) A coin minted to advertise a ruler's military power
 - (B) A copper plate recording a tax-free land grant
 - (C) A court poet's inscription praising a king
 - (D) A riverbank or forest revered as holy, where pilgrims gather and Nature is protected
- 29.** A visitor claims, 'Sacred geography of this kind exists only in India.' The chapter would judge this claim:
- (A) Correct, because no other country has any holy places
 - (B) Mistaken, because reverence for sacred landscapes is found in other parts of the world too

- (C) Correct, because the idea was first invented in modern Europe
- (D) Mistaken, because India in fact has no sacred geography at all

30. Which conclusion about India's sacred geography is BEST supported by the chapter taken as a whole?

- (A) It mattered only to traders chasing profit along the routes
- (B) It permanently divided India into mutually hostile faiths
- (C) It appeared only in modern times with no earlier history
- (D) It blended faith, Nature and movement across the land into a force that long unified a diverse subcontinent

31. The chapter says sacred geography knit India together 'for at least three thousand years.' This long span is meant to establish that the integrating force was:

- (A) A brief modern campaign limited to recent decades
- (B) Active only during one particular dynasty's rule
- (C) Deep and continuous, shaping the civilisation over a vast stretch of time
- (D) Operative for a single century before stopping

32. A faith that arrived in India from OUTSIDE came over time to have deeply revered sites here. The chapter explains this mainly by saying that:

- (A) Each outside faith was handed exactly one site by royal decree
- (B) Such faiths merely renamed existing temples and changed nothing
- (C) Over centuries its followers settled, built and honoured holy places that wove into India's sacred geography
- (D) Only the government could grant an outside faith any holy place

33. A relic and a sangam are easily confused on a vocabulary test. Which pairing distinguishes them correctly?

- (A) A relic is a meeting of rivers; a sangam is a holy figure's belonging
- (B) A relic is a tax-free land grant; a sangam is a dating era
- (C) A relic is a sky-based festival cycle; a sangam is a fig tree
- (D) A relic is a holy figure's bodily part or belonging; a sangam is a meeting of rivers

34. A 'shrine' is regarded as holy chiefly because of its association with:

- (A) A famous battle and nothing more
- (B) The divine, a sacred relic, or a revered spiritual figure
- (C) A busy market town and nothing more
- (D) A royal coronation and nothing more

35. The great epics, the chapter says, helped SCATTER sacred sites across India. They did this by:

- (A) Forbidding pilgrimage to every place they named
- (B) Linking many places to the journeys and deeds of their heroes, so those places became holy

- (C) Naming only one single holy place in all of India
- (D) Describing imaginary lands with no real locations

36. A class is asked which item, when added to a list, would BREAK the pattern 'things that turn the whole land into a sacred geography.' Which item breaks it?

- (A) A coin minted to advertise a ruler's military strength
- (B) Networks of shrines scattered to the four edges of the country
- (C) Rivers, mountains and forests revered across many regions
- (D) Long pilgrim journeys that carry people and customs between regions

37. A student lists peepal, banyan, the Bodhi tree and a sangam together as 'sacred living things.' Which item does NOT belong, and why?

- (A) The sangam, because it is a meeting of rivers, not a living thing
- (B) The peepal, because fig trees are not really alive
- (C) The banyan, because it is a kind of building
- (D) The Bodhi tree, because it was a stone pillar

38. Why does the chapter present the difficult, far-flung placement of holy sites as a UNIFYING rather than fragmenting feature?

- (A) The distances kept each region permanently apart from the others
- (B) Reaching the scattered sites required long journeys that mixed people, languages and customs across regions
- (C) Only one of the sites was ever actually visited
- (D) Travel between regions was forbidden to ordinary people

39. Assertion: Many pilgrimage centres in India grew into busy market towns. Reason: Crowds of travelling pilgrims created steady demand for food, lodging and supplies, which drew traders to settle. Which evaluation is correct?

- (A) Both the assertion and the reason are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion
- (B) Both are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (C) The assertion is true but the reason is false
- (D) The assertion is false but the reason is true

40. Which example BEST demonstrates that a single sacred place can matter to MORE THAN ONE religious tradition?

- (A) A temple that admits worshippers of only its own sect
- (B) A royal palace open exclusively to the king's family
- (C) A Sufi dargah honoured by people of several different faiths
- (D) A market square used solely for buying and selling

41. Across India, river confluences, hilltop shrines and ocean-edge temples are ALL called tirthas. The single unifying reason is that each is imagined as a:

- (A) Place where rivers physically begin their flow
- (B) Boundary stone marking the edge of a kingdom
- (C) Site reserved only for royal ceremonies
- (D) Crossing point between the ordinary world and a higher, sacred realm

42. Which best shows that, in India, geography and spirituality 'fuse together' rather than merely sit side by side?

- (A) A temple is built and the surrounding landscape is then ignored
- (B) Worship happens only indoors, away from any natural feature
- (C) Natural features are valued purely for farming and never for faith
- (D) A mountain or river is itself worshipped as divine, not merely as a backdrop to worship

43. Which fact about the duty to protect sacred places TODAY follows MOST directly from the chapter's reasoning?

- (A) They are useless relics best left to decay
- (B) They are a shared heritage of Nature and culture, so protecting them is worthwhile for everyone
- (C) They matter only for the tourism income they bring
- (D) They are the private property of traders alone

44. 'Conservation', as the chapter ties it to sacred places, is best defined as:

- (A) Clearing forests quickly for the largest possible profit
- (B) Building over rivers and confluences to expand cities
- (C) Protecting and keeping Nature, biodiversity or heritage safe for the future
- (D) Discarding old traditions in favour of new construction

45. A planner wants to protect a biodiverse forest cheaply and durably. Drawing on the chapter's grove example, which approach best fits its logic?

- (A) Strengthen the community's belief that the forest is sacred and must not be harmed
- (B) Post armed guards and rely on heavy fines alone
- (C) Wall off the forest and lock every entrance
- (D) Pay the villagers an annual fee to leave it alone

46. A traveller notices that a single famous shrine sits exactly where several pilgrimage routes AND trade routes cross. The chapter's best explanation is that:

- (A) Shrines were forbidden anywhere except at empty crossroads
- (B) The constant flow of both pilgrims and traders made such a junction naturally busy and important
- (C) Traders were paid to keep all their routes away from shrines
- (D) Pilgrims and traders were never permitted to meet on one road

- 47.** Why does the chapter describe rivers, hills and groves as sacred 'across many religions and communities' rather than to one faith alone?
- (A) The government assigns each natural feature to one religion at a time
 - (B) Only the oldest religion is permitted to revere Nature
 - (C) People of different faiths sharing a region have come to revere the same natural features
 - (D) Such reverence lasts only one year before being reassigned
- 48.** A Tirthankara, a sangam, a relic and a jyotirlinga are mixed in a matching exercise. Which definition is correctly paired?
- (A) Tirthankara — a supreme Jain teacher, literally 'one who makes a crossing'
 - (B) Sangam — a part or belonging of a holy figure kept in reverence
 - (C) Relic — a confluence where two or more rivers meet
 - (D) Jyotirlinga — one of the 51 sites of the goddess
- 49.** Order these networks from SMALLEST traditional count to LARGEST: jyotirlingas, char dham, Shakti pithas. The correct order is:
- (A) Jyotirlingas (12), char dham (4), Shakti pithas (51)
 - (B) Char dham (4), Shakti pithas (51), jyotirlingas (12)
 - (C) Char dham (4), jyotirlingas (12), Shakti pithas (51)
 - (D) Shakti pithas (51), jyotirlingas (12), char dham (4)
- 50.** A pilgrim who is also a merchant says the same trip lets him 'worship and earn at once.' Which chapter idea does his remark most directly illustrate?
- (A) That pilgrims were forbidden to carry any money
 - (B) That sacred sites and markets were always kept far apart
 - (C) That religious life and economic life were closely woven together along shared routes
 - (D) That trade existed only inside temple compounds
- 51.** Which statement about the jyotirlingas is fully correct?
- (A) They are fifty-one shrines dedicated to the goddess
 - (B) They are twelve shrines, all dedicated to Shiva
 - (C) They are four shrines dedicated to Vishnu
 - (D) They are seven shrines dedicated to the Buddha
- 52.** A teacher draws 'tirtha' at the centre of a web with branches to 'river ford', 'Tirthankara' and 'hilltop shrine.' The single idea linking all three branches is:
- (A) A crossing from ordinary life toward a higher, spiritual state
 - (B) The requirement that each lie physically beside flowing water
 - (C) The granting of tax-free land to those who founded them
 - (D) The rule that only one religion may use each of them

53. Which pairing of a holy thing with the religion it ORIGINATED with is correctly matched?

- (A) The 12 jyotirlingas — Jainism
- (B) The 51 Shakti pithas — Buddhism
- (C) The char dham — Sikhism
- (D) The Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya — Buddhism

54. Assertion: Treating the whole land as sacred has helped conserve Nature in India.

Reason: When rivers, mountains and forests are seen as holy, people gain a strong motive to protect them. Which evaluation is correct?

- (A) Both are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (B) The assertion is true but the reason is false
- (C) Both the assertion and the reason are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion
- (D) The assertion is false but the reason is true

55. Which set correctly names the four char dham that ring the country at its directional extremes?

- (A) Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri and Rameswaram
- (B) Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain
- (C) Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar and Lumbini
- (D) Badrinath, Kanchipuram, Madurai and Dwarka

56. A student summarises the whole chapter in one line. Which line is the most accurate summary of 'how the land becomes sacred'?

- (A) Through pilgrimage, networks of sites and revered Nature, the whole land — not just shrines — comes to be seen as holy
- (B) Only a single temple in all India is truly holy
- (C) Land becomes sacred only when a king formally declares it so
- (D) Sacredness has nothing to do with geography at all

57. Imagine a new map that marks every revered river, hill, forest, tree, dargah, temple and pilgrim route in India. The chapter would say such a map best proves that:

- (A) Sacredness in India is confined to a handful of grand buildings
- (B) Each marked site is sealed off and revered by only one faith
- (C) Holy sites are concentrated in a single region of the country
- (D) The country forms one connected sacred geography in which the land itself, not only its buildings, is holy

58. Two pilgrims meet at a hilltop dargah: one is Muslim, one is Hindu, and both have come to pray. A sceptic says, 'One of them must be at the wrong place.' Which chapter idea best answers the sceptic?

- (A) Each sacred site is reserved by law for a single religion
- (B) Many of India's holy places are shared, drawing reverence from people of several faiths at once

(C) Only the faith that founded a site may ever worship there

(D) A site loses its holiness if more than one faith visits it

59. A student writes that 'the goddess network has 12 sites and the Shiva network has 51.'
The teacher marks it wrong. The precise error is that the student:

(A) Swapped the counts — the goddess (Shakti) pithas are 51 and the Shiva jyotirlingas are 12

(B) Confused both networks with the four char dham

(C) Was right about the numbers but wrong about the deities

(D) Used counts that belong to the Kumbh's four cities

60. A planner wants ONE policy that captures everything the chapter values about sacred land: reverence, conservation and the fusion of geography with spirituality. Which best fits?

(A) Recognise revered rivers, forests and hills as a shared natural-and-cultural heritage worth protecting

(B) Convert each sacred site into a fee-charging tourist attraction

(C) Assign every natural feature to a single religion to avoid disputes

(D) Replace open sacred landscapes with a few grand new buildings

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 8: How the Land Becomes Sacred — Paper 5

Paper 5 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	D	11	C	21	A	31	C	41	D	51	B
2	D	12	B	22	D	32	C	42	D	52	A
3	B	13	C	23	C	33	D	43	B	53	D
4	D	14	C	24	B	34	B	44	C	54	C
5	C	15	D	25	A	35	B	45	A	55	A
6	A	16	C	26	B	36	A	46	B	56	A
7	D	17	B	27	A	37	A	47	C	57	D
8	D	18	B	28	D	38	B	48	A	58	B
9	C	19	A	29	B	39	A	49	C	59	A
10	D	20	B	30	D	40	C	50	C	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (D) The chapter's central claim is that sacredness reaches beyond buildings into Nature and journeys, so revered rivers, hills, forests and the act of pilgrimage would keep the land sacred even with no temples. Rebuilding one tall temple, or a single great stone shrine, stays inside the 'buildings only' view the chapter explicitly widens. A government register of buildings is administrative, not a source of sacredness, and again fixes sacredness to structures.

2. (D) The chapter takes 'tirtha' (literally a river-ford) and extends it metaphorically to a crossing from the ordinary toward the higher, which is the deeper sense it stresses. 'River' captures only the literal ford and wrongly implies every tirtha must lie on water. 'Peak' confuses tirtha with sacred mountains, a separate idea. 'Nectar' belongs to the Kumbh's pot-of-amrita legend, not to the meaning of tirtha.

3. (B) The chapter applies 'tirtha' to confluences, hilltops and seaside temples alike because all are imagined as crossing-points toward the sacred, so the metaphor, not the

literal ford, governs. Restricting tirthas to riverbanks ignores that extension. Hills and oceans are revered across the same traditions, not split by religion. Hilltop shrines plainly exist in the chapter, so denying them is false.

4. (D) 'Tirthankara' literally means 'maker of a tirtha (crossing)', so the title frames the teacher as one who enables the passage to a higher, liberated life, matching the chapter's crossing-metaphor. Building a tall shrine confuses holiness with size. Granting tax-free land belongs to royal land-grants, a different chapter's theme. Forming a river describes a sangam, not a Tirthankara.

5. (C) The char dham are deliberately placed at the country's four directional extremes, so a single pilgrimage loop sweeps across the entire land and ties distant regions together. A northern valley, a single city, or a tight radius would cluster the sites and defeat the integrating effect the chapter highlights.

6. (A) The chapter fixes char dham at 4, jyotirlingas at 12 (Shiva), and Shakti pithas at 51 (the goddess Sati). Swapping char dham to 12 and jyotirlingas to 4-Vishnu fails both count and deity. Putting 51 on the jyotirlingas and 12 on the pithas swaps the two large networks. Assigning the goddess to the jyotirlingas and Shiva to the pithas swaps the deities.

7. (D) Spreading 51 sites across the land creates a single goddess-geography linking distant regions, which is exactly the integrating effect the chapter draws. Confining worship to one shrine, or sealing regions off, is the opposite of scattering. The pithas never become jyotirlingas; that conflates two distinct networks.

8. (D) The chapter stresses that faiths originating in India and those arriving from outside both mark sacred places here, so dargahs and churches do count. Crediting only the oldest religion ignores that breadth. Claiming outside faiths merely renamed temples misreads how their followers built and honoured their own sites. Government recognition is irrelevant to a place being sacred.

9. (C) The chapter names Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism as the faiths that arose in India. Islam, Christianity and Zoroastrianism arrived from outside, so each of the other groups smuggles in a non-Indian-origin faith and fails.

10. (D) Worshippers of several faiths at one shrine directly refutes the idea that a site serves only one religion, which is the chapter's 'shared sites' point. The antiquity of pilgrimage, the sacredness of Nature, and the pilgrimage-trade overlap are all true chapter themes but are not what a single shared dargah is being used to disprove here.

11. (C) The chapter reads the demanding climb as a mirror of inner spiritual effort, giving the hardship purpose. Keeping pilgrims away contradicts the welcoming aim of pilgrimage. Calling it accidental denies the symbolism the chapter draws. Treating it as a strength contest reduces a spiritual idea to athletics.

- 12. (B)** Integration in the chapter comes from long pilgrim journeys mixing people and customs across regions; clustering the sites removes those long journeys and so removes the integrating effect. River links, festival attendance and government recognition are not the mechanism the chapter credits for integration, so they are weaker explanations.
- 13. (C)** The chapter explains that pilgrims needed food and lodging, so traders worked the same busy roads, making the route maps coincide. Separate roads contradict that overlap. Building trade routes only after pilgrimage ended is invented and reverses the chapter's point. Calling it coincidence ignores the stated cause.
- 14. (C)** If pilgrims and merchants never shared roads, the overlap the chapter rests on would collapse, so that finding undermines the claim. Shrines at crossroads, festival crowds and long pilgrim journeys all reinforce the intertwining rather than threaten it.
- 15. (D)** A confluence is a place where waters cross and join, which directly enacts the tirtha idea of a crossing. Rivers do not stop at a sangam, and that misreads moving water. Bathing is in fact central at sangams, not forbidden. A tax boundary is a political, not sacred, notion.
- 16. (C)** The Kumbh follows a roughly twelve-year sky-based cycle (so 'every year' is wrong) and rotates among four cities (so 'same town' is wrong) — exactly two errors. 'None' ignores both. 'One' misses the rotation error. 'Three' wrongly adds that the festival does not exist, which is false.
- 17. (B)** The chapter fixes the Kumbh by astronomical positions of Jupiter and the Sun on a ~12-year cycle across four cities. Monsoon rainfall, a kings' vote and a new temple's completion are all invented triggers that contradict the sky-based, multi-city rotation.
- 18. (B)** 'Kumbh' means pot and recalls the pot of amrita (nectar) of legend, paired with 'mela' (fair). A mountain-source, a coronation crown and a fig-tree proclamation are all distractors built from other chapter themes (sacred mountains, kingship, sacred trees) and do not explain 'kumbh'.
- 19. (A)** Bathing at the sangam ties the Kumbh to the tirtha-as-crossing idea, explaining the huge gatherings. Saying the festival has no river link contradicts the bathing itself. Banning bathing at confluences is the reverse of the practice. Placing the Kumbh on a hilltop ignores its riverbank character.
- 20. (B)** Calling a peak a gateway to heaven shows physical landscape and spiritual meaning merging, the chapter's fusion idea. Saying only plains can be sacred contradicts the very example. Keeping geography and religion apart is the opposite of fusion. Treating mountains only as borders strips away their sacred meaning.
- 21. (A)** The chapter dates river and confluence worship to at least Vedic times, underscoring its antiquity. The last hundred years, the post-Gupta centuries and the

modern-city era all wrongly make an ancient practice recent.

22. (D) A holy tree shows sacredness extending into living Nature beyond buildings, the chapter's point. Restricting holiness to fig trees overgeneralises from one example. Limiting it to buildings contradicts the very tree. Saying the Buddha forbade natural reverence reverses the example, since the Bodhi tree is itself revered.

23. (C) A trade-derived name for a revered tree links commerce with cultural and sacred life, the chapter's interwoven theme. Claiming the tree was sacred only to traders narrows a broadly revered tree. Forbidding traders from resting there contradicts the very story of the name. Naming trees after kings is invented.

24. (B) The banyan spreads because aerial roots descend and become new trunks, so one tree covers a large area. Golden leaves, a stone trunk and Kumbh-timed flowers are all invented and have nothing to do with the tree's spreading habit.

25. (A) Sacred groves survive mainly through community belief that they are a deity's dwelling, which is why no fence or law is needed. State laws and police, a walled enclosure, and royal payments all replace belief with external force, contradicting the chapter's account of belief-driven protection.

26. (B) Belief-protected groves show culture conserving Nature without law, the chapter's lesson. Requiring police contradicts the very example of unguarded groves. Saying belief always harms Nature reverses the finding. Limiting protection to cities ignores rural groves entirely.

27. (A) The belief simultaneously voices reverence and protects the ecosystem, hence 'double duty.' Turning the grove into policed state land replaces belief with law. Inviting logging and mining is the opposite of protection. Claiming only buildings are sacred contradicts the grove being sacred at all.

28. (D) A punyakshetra is a stretch of land where landscape, culture and the sacred merge, exactly a revered riverbank or forest drawing pilgrims. A coin, a land-grant plate and a praise inscription are administrative or political objects with no fusion of geography and spirituality.

29. (B) The chapter notes sacred geography appears elsewhere too, so the 'only India' claim is mistaken. Saying no other country has holy places is plainly false. Crediting modern Europe with inventing it is invented. Denying India any sacred geography contradicts the whole chapter.

30. (D) The chapter's overall argument is that sacred geography fused faith, Nature and pilgrim movement to unify a diverse land over millennia. Reducing it to traders' profit ignores its devotional and natural sides. Saying it divided India reverses its integrating role. Calling it purely modern contradicts the 3000-year span.

31. (C) A 3000-year span signals a deep, continuous force, not a passing event. A recent campaign, a single dynasty and a one-century span all shrink the timeframe and miss the chapter's point about endurance.

32. (C) Outside faiths gained sacred sites because their followers settled and built and revered places over generations, integrating them into the sacred landscape. A single royal decree, mere renaming of temples, or government grants all misdescribe this organic, centuries-long process.

33. (D) A relic is a revered bodily part or object of a holy figure, while a sangam is a river confluence. The other options swap the two, or substitute unrelated terms (land grant, dating era, festival cycle, fig tree) that belong to different ideas entirely.

34. (B) A shrine draws its holiness from the divine, a relic, or a spiritual figure. A battle, a market town or a coronation are secular associations and do not, on their own, make a place a shrine in the chapter's sense.

35. (B) By tying heroes' journeys and deeds to many real places, the epics made those places sacred and spread them across the land. Forbidding pilgrimage, naming a single place, or describing only imaginary lands all contradict the scattering effect the chapter credits to the epics.

36. (A) Scattered shrine-networks, revered Nature, and long pilgrim journeys all spread sacredness across the land. A coin advertising a ruler's army is a political object that does nothing to make the land sacred, so it breaks the pattern.

37. (A) A sangam is a river confluence, not a living organism, so it does not belong with the trees. The peepal and banyan are living fig trees, and the Bodhi tree was itself a peepal — all living — so calling them non-living, a building, or a stone pillar is false.

38. (B) Long journeys to scattered sites mixed people and customs, which integrates rather than divides. The distances did not isolate regions; they were bridged by pilgrims. Saying only one site was visited, or that ordinary travel was forbidden, both contradict the busy pilgrim movement the chapter describes.

39. (A) Pilgrim crowds created demand that traders met, so towns grew up — the reason directly explains the assertion, and both are true. Denying the explanatory link ignores the cause-and-effect the chapter draws. The assertion and the reason are both genuinely true, so the options calling either false are wrong.

40. (C) A dargah revered by several faiths is the textbook shared site. A single-sect temple serves one tradition only. A royal palace and a market square are not sacred and not shared across faiths, so none of the distractors fits the 'more than one tradition' test.

41. (D) All three are tirthas because each is conceived as a crossing toward the sacred. Rivers beginning their flow describes a source, not a crossing. A boundary stone is political. A royal-only site contradicts the open, devotional nature of a tirtha.

42. (D) Fusion means the landform itself is divine, so worshipping a mountain or river directly shows it. Ignoring the landscape, worshipping only indoors, or valuing Nature only for farming all keep geography and spirituality apart, the opposite of fusion.

43. (B) Because sacred places blend Nature and culture as a shared heritage, the chapter implies a shared duty to protect them. Calling them useless relics, valuing them only for tourism, or treating them as traders' property all ignore the heritage-and-conservation argument the chapter builds.

44. (C) Conservation here means safeguarding Nature and heritage for the future. Clearing forests for profit, building over rivers, and discarding traditions are all forms of destruction, the opposite of conservation.

45. (A) The grove example shows belief protecting forests cheaply and lastingly without law, so reinforcing sacred belief fits the chapter's logic. Armed guards and fines, walls and locks, and annual payments all rely on external force or money, which the chapter shows is not what kept groves safe.

46. (B) Shared roads carried both pilgrims and traders, so a route-junction became a busy, important spot for a shrine. Forbidding shrines except at empty crossroads is invented. Paying traders to stay away, or barring pilgrims and traders from meeting, both contradict the overlap the chapter describes.

47. (C) Shared regions led people of different faiths to revere the same Nature, hence 'across many communities.' Government assignment, a monopoly for the oldest religion, and yearly reassignment are all invented mechanisms that contradict the organic, shared reverence the chapter describes.

48. (A) A Tirthankara is a supreme Jain teacher, 'maker of a crossing.' A sangam is a river confluence (not a relic), a relic is a holy figure's part or belonging (not a confluence), and a jyotirlinga is one of 12 Shiva shrines (not one of the 51 goddess sites), so the other pairings are swapped or miscounted.

49. (C) From smallest to largest: char dham 4, jyotirlingas 12, Shakti pithas 51. Putting jyotirlingas before char dham breaks the order. Putting the pithas before the jyotirlingas reverses 12 and 51. Listing the pithas first is largest-to-smallest, the reverse of what is asked.

50. (C) Worshipping and trading on one journey shows religious and economic life intertwined, the chapter's overlap theme. Forbidding pilgrims money, keeping sites and

markets apart, and confining trade to temples all contradict the merging of devotion and commerce.

51. (B) The jyotirlingas are twelve Shiva shrines. Fifty-one with the goddess describes the Shakti pithas; four with Vishnu echoes a miscount of the char dham; seven with the Buddha is invented. Only the twelve-Shiva pairing is right.

52. (A) All three branches share the crossing-metaphor: a ford crosses water, a Tirthankara makes a crossing, a hilltop shrine is a crossing toward the divine. Requiring flowing water fits only the ford. Tax-free land and single-religion rules are unrelated to the shared root and are invented.

53. (D) The Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya is central to Buddhism. The jyotirlingas are Shaiva (Hindu), not Jain; the Shakti pithas are goddess sites in the Hindu tradition, not Buddhist; the char dham are Hindu abodes, not Sikh. Only the Bodhi-tree pairing is correct.

54. (C) Seeing Nature as holy gives people a motive to protect it, which is precisely how sacredness has aided conservation, so the reason explains the assertion and both are true. Denying the link ignores the chapter's causal point, and both statements are genuinely true, so the options calling either false fail.

55. (A) The char dham are Badrinath (north), Dwarka (west), Puri (east) and Rameswaram (south). Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain are the four Kumbh cities. Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar and Lumbini are Buddhist sites. The last list mixes in southern temple towns that are not the char dham.

56. (A) The chapter's thesis is that pilgrimage, site-networks and revered Nature together make the whole land sacred, far beyond shrines. A single holy temple, a king's declaration, or denying any link to geography each contradict that central message.

57. (D) A map dense with revered Nature, routes and shared shrines across the country demonstrates one connected sacred geography where the land itself is holy. Confining sacredness to grand buildings, sealing each site to one faith, or concentrating sites in one region all contradict the chapter's spread-out, shared, Nature-inclusive picture.

58. (B) The chapter's shared-site theme means both pilgrims are rightly there, since many holy places draw several faiths together. Reserving sites by law for one religion, restricting worship to the founding faith, and claiming a site loses holiness when shared all contradict the chapter's account of cross-faith reverence.

59. (A) The Shakti pithas number 51 and the jyotirlingas 12, so the student reversed the two figures. The mistake is not about the char dham, which number 4. The deities are correctly matched but the counts are swapped, so 'right numbers, wrong deities' is the reverse of the actual error. The Kumbh's four cities are unrelated to either count.

60. (A) Protecting revered Nature as shared heritage honours reverence, conserves the ecosystem and treats landscape as spiritually meaningful — the chapter's full package. Turning sites into fee attractions reduces them to tourism income; assigning features to one religion denies their shared character; replacing landscapes with buildings reverses the chapter's move beyond mere structures.